

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AFP

Donald Trump said he would soon make a decision on a deal with **Iran**. In a social-media post he wrote that the Strait of Hormuz must be reopened to commercial shipping and that America would lift its blockade. He also claimed that Iran's enriched material would be "unearthed" and destroyed by America. Iran has not responded to his post.

Binyamin Netanyahu said he directed **Israel's** armed forces to seize at least 70% of **Gaza**. The prime minister's order would violate a ceasefire agreement that America brokered in October, in which Israel agreed to leave just over half of the enclave occupied. Meanwhile, Israel continued striking southern **Lebanon**, despite a supposed ceasefire.

A federal judge temporarily blocked the **Trump administration** from implementing a **\$1.8bn fund** to pay alleged victims of government "lawfare". The "**Anti-Weaponisation Fund**" is facing several lawsuits. In this one, a group of challengers argued that it would unfairly benefit people claiming to have been harmed by Democratic, but not Republican, administrations.

Three Chinese astronauts landed at the Dongfeng landing site in inner Mongolia after more than 200 days in space. The Shenzhou-

21 mission, which launched in October, became the longest in-orbit stay by a Chinese crew. China aims to land on the Moon in 2030, whereas America [plans to do so earlier](#). The countries are locked in a heated space race.

The EU has agreed to unlock €16bn (\$19bn) in frozen funds to **Hungary** after a meeting with Peter Magyar, the country's new prime minister. The bloc had withheld financing due to the rule-of-law violations of Viktor Orbán's government. Mr Magyar, who won the election [on a pledge to clean up the country](#), said the money will help "jump-start the economy".

A **Russian drone** entered **Romania** and struck a block of flats in Galati, a city near the border with Ukraine, according to the Romanian defence ministry. The crash started a fire and injured two people. Several Russian drones have entered the NATO country's airspace since the invasion of Ukraine in 2022. Ursula von der Leyen, the head of the European Commission, said Russia's war had "crossed yet another line".

Japan's population fell by 3m between 2020 and 2025, the sharpest decline on record, according to preliminary census data. With 123m people, the country has returned to its population of the late 1980s. The country has [long struggled](#) with an ageing population and a declining birth rate.

Figure of the day: 65, the number of active state-based conflicts in 2025, the highest level since record-keeping began in 1946. Read about how [wars have changed](#).



Photograph: Getty Images

No Shangri-La for China

Pete Hegseth, America's secretary of war, has travelled to Singapore for the Shangri-La Dialogue, an annual gabfest of defence ministers, military commanders and spy chiefs that began on Friday. But his Chinese counterpart, Admiral Dong Jun, will not be there. This is a sign that China's beleaguered military leaders are keeping a low profile. Many have been removed from their posts in recent months [following accusations of corruption](#).

The no-show is a missed opportunity for America and China to talk. Their defence chiefs once spoke every year at the Shangri-La Dialogue. Yet China was never fully comfortable at the event, where its leaders faced difficult questions that they would not be asked back home. In the keynote address, [To Lam](#), Vietnam's recently re-elected president, is expected to call for greater co-operation among middle powers caught between an adversarial America and China.



Photograph: EPA

The widening war in Lebanon

Iran has repeatedly insisted that its shaky ceasefire agreement with America, reached several weeks ago, covers Lebanon. Israel, however, denies this. And its battle with Hizbullah, the Iran-backed militia in Lebanon, is escalating. On Thursday Israel ordered the evacuation of much of southern Lebanon, as it carried out air strikes on the city of Tyre. Hizbullah said it had engaged with Israeli troops at “point-blank range” in a nearby town.

Israeli army officers say their main objective in southern Lebanon is to push Hizbullah’s drone operators farther from the border. So far they have failed. Hizbullah has continued to hit Israeli troops and civilians with drones, defying demands by the Lebanese government that it stop. Meanwhile American-mediated talks to end [the war](#) have been taking place in Washington, DC. Yet they seem to have no effect on what is happening on the ground.

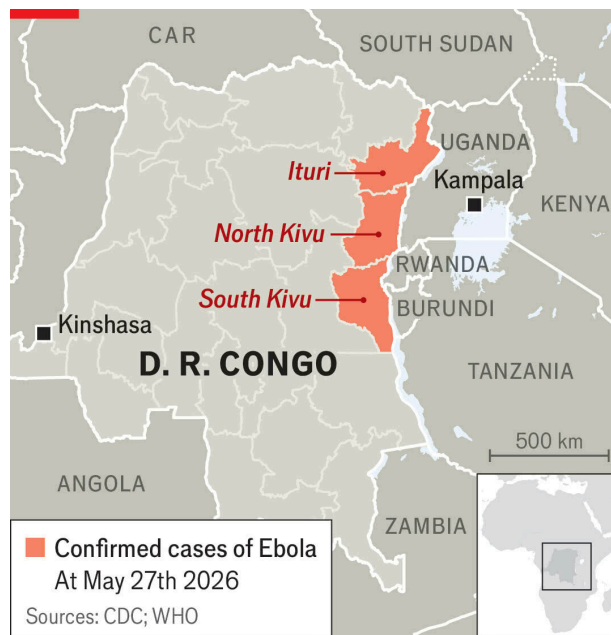


Photograph: EPA

Ebola rips through Congo

The worst [outbreak of Ebola](#) since 2018 is spreading fast. More than 1,000 suspected cases and around 250 suspected deaths have been recorded in the Democratic Republic of Congo. The real tally is almost certainly much higher, because authorities are struggling to identify, test and track patients. Ebola is also reaching other countries. Uganda, which abuts the province at the centre of the outbreak, has confirmed seven cases and closed its border with Congo.

The response has been late and chaotic. That is partly because working in eastern Congo is extremely difficult. The region is poor and full of militias. People have little trust in officials who are marshalling the response. Before the outbreak donors had also cut funding for schemes that tracked Ebola. Those donors are now sending more cash to help health-care workers. Meanwhile scientists are racing to make an experimental vaccine. But that will take, at best, two to three months.





Photograph: Alamy

When DEET smells like dinner

Dogs can be trained as guides, crows to pick up litter and rats to sniff out landmines. [New research](#), published in the *Journal of Experimental Biology*, reveals that even the seemingly mindless mosquito is capable of learning.

A team of researchers led by Claudio Lazzari, a behavioural physiologist at University of Tours in France, presented mosquitoes with sheep's blood while they were exposed to a breeze, some of which was tainted with DEET. The same mosquitoes were then presented with a pair of researchers' hands: one sprayed with the potent bug-repellent; the other without. Some 60% of the mosquitoes that had previously been exposed to both blood and DEET at the same time immediately flew to the repellent-coated hand.

Dr Lazzari concludes that these insects learned to associate the bug-spray with food, turning a repellent into a lure. There is a good chance that, in the real world, mosquitoes are learning the same thing.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: What is the civilian name of the superhero “The Thing” in the Fantastic Four stories?

Thursday: Which philosopher and economist was born in Trier in 1818 and died in London in 1883?

*Conformity is the jailer of
freedom and the enemy of growth.*

John F. Kennedy